Eli R. Hooten, Ph.D.

CTO / Developer / Engineer

elir.hooten@gmail.com | elihooten.com | linkedin.com/in/hootener | github.com/hootener

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

I am a multi-time CTO and technical co-founder with over a decade of startup leadership, having scaled engineering, product, and design teams from 0–30+ and led two companies to eight figures in acquisition. My background spans system architecture, product discovery and validation, open source, fundraising, and business strategy, and I now co-found and build AI-powered software in a high-ownership environment at Line.

EXPERIENCE

CTO / Co-Founder

2025 – Present

Line; Remote

Line builds an AI sales agent for hospitality venues that works inbound event inquiries end to end — first guest message through qualification, proposal, and signed contract.

- Shipped an AI sales agent to multiple venues where it has worked over 600 real world guest inquiries, with over 80% fully resolved by the sales agent.
- Designed a pre-send hallucination gate that corrected 24.3% of all agent messages, removing agent fabrications before they reached a guest.
- Deployed an AI-first development pipeline that runs isolated coding agents on dedicated infrastructure and returns a reviewed, quality-gated pull request with no human in the loop.
- Drove a two-engineer team to over 1,600 merged pull requests in 14 months, with 75% agent-authored under human review.
- Built the test and review foundation that enabled our velocity: 20,000+ automated tests including 124 Playwright end-to-end journeys, AI review on every pull request, and sharded self-hosted CI that returns a full verdict in ~12 minutes and gated 726 production deploys.
- Partnered with the founding team on fundraising, technical diligence, and company strategy, translating architecture and technical risk for investors.

Director of Engineering, Codecov

2022 – 2025

Sentry; Remote

- Served as the technical and product leader for Codecov post-acquisition, guiding product strategy and execution within the larger Sentry organization.
- Devised and led the evolution of Codecov from a code coverage tool into a broader code quality platform, aligning roadmap and architecture with customer needs.
- Scaled Engineering, Design, and Product functions, hiring both individual contributors and managers across multiple product areas.
- Drove the transition of Codecov from closed source to a Fair Source License project, shaping processes, tooling, and community-facing practices.

CTO / Co-Founder *2018 – 2022*

Codecov; Remote

I was the Co-Founder/CTO of Codecov and led it from a team of 3 to a globally distributed team of over 30. Codecov was acquired by Sentry in 2022.

- Multiplied annual recurring revenue by 10x from 2019 - 2022.
- Grew Codecov to one of the most installed App Integrations on GitHub, used by over a million software developers worldwide.
- Built and led the engineering, product, design, technical support, security, and solutions engineering teams.
- Scaled the organization from 3 to 30+ people globally, building a distributed engineering culture and leadership layer to support continued growth.
- Participated in strategy setting, fundraising, and acquisition processes with leadership team.

CTO / Co-Founder *2012 – 2018*

GameWisp, Inc.; Nashville, TN

GameWisp's core technology was acquired by Lightstream in 2019.

- Built a first of its kind, world class, recurring subscription and benefits platform that was acquired by Lightstream in 2019.
- Grew from $0 to over $5M in annual recurring revenue.
- Designed and developed video upload, encoding, and delivery systems to support high-quality streaming and on-demand content for thousands of end users.
- Developed public APIs that were consumed by a broad ecosystem of external integrations and delivered functionality to hundreds of thousands of end users.

Research Assistant *2009 – 2014*

Department of Electrical Engineering and Computer Science; Vanderbilt University; Nashville, TN

- Developed software design prototypes for academic research using a variety of languages and platforms.
- Performed statistical analysis to support research findings and system evaluations.
- Served as a peer leader and manager to both graduate and undergraduate researchers.
- Published award-winning, peer-reviewed research in human factors and human-robot interaction.
- Designed and tested unmanned aerial vehicles and balloons for archaeological field use, integrating hardware and software components.
- Supported survey teams on-site in the Peruvian highlands with hardware and software setup and troubleshooting.

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Computer Science *2014*

Vanderbilt University, Nashville, TN

M.Sc., Electrical Engineering *2010*

Vanderbilt University, Nashville, TN

B.Sc., Engineering Physics *2009*

Murray State University, Murray, KY

SKILLS

CTO leadership · System architecture · Software engineering · Technical leadership · Product management · Team scaling · Business strategy · Fundraising · Web APIs (REST, WebSocket) · Open source development · Statistical analysis · Developer tools · Code quality platforms

PROJECTS

Line — Designed an AI driven system to simplify group business in hospitality, from initial guest inquiry to contract.

Codecov — Built and evolved large, complex web software at scale, including core components later formalized into the commercial platform. Much of the codebase is now open source.

Subscriptions — Created a fan monetization and rewards platform for live-streamers; underlying GameWisp technology was acquired by Lightstream in 2019.

Video Platform — Developed video functionality for content upload, distribution, and scheduling premium video for creators.

Singularity APIs — Designed and implemented WebSocket and REST APIs for the GameWisp subscriptions platform that were adopted by hundreds of developers.